

Emotional Desertification in Puerto Rican LGBT Dating Culture

I. The Desert

While talking to a close friend about my latest emotional struggle, I ended up saying something that came out so naturally, it actually stopped the conversation for a second. It just felt so correct. **"Emotional Desertification"**

And the more I've thought about it since then, the more it fits what I've been seeing and living through in the gay community, especially here in Puerto Rico.

It's not that there aren't people. There are, in fact, plenty. There's no shortage of messages, matches, attention, or ways to meet someone. You can open an app and, in a few minutes, be talking to someone who's down to hook up. In that sense, connection has never been easier. But that's the problem. Because what's easy to start is also easy to drop. And what's harder and harder to find isn't access to people, it's anything that actually feels stable. Trust, consistency, honesty, emotional depth. The kind of things that make a connection feel like it's going somewhere instead of just passing through.

A lot of interactions now feel like they start fast, burn bright for a second, and then just... fade. Or they don't even fade properly. They just stop. No explanation, no closure, just silence or distance that slowly replaces whatever was there. At first, you treat each one like its own thing. Just a random bad experience. Someone who wasn't serious. Someone who just wasn't for you. Someone... who wasn't ready. But after a while, they stop feeling separate. They start to look the same. Same rhythm, pattern, and ending. The only difference, is the face.

And that does something to you over time. You stop walking into things with open curiosity and start walking in already half-prepared for it to end. Not because you want to be cynical, but because your brain starts adjusting to what keeps happening. That's where the "desert" part comes in. Not emptiness, but erosion. Not nothing existing, but things slowly losing the ability to even exist.

Still, I can't fully pretend this is just about other people. Because I also know what I bring into these spaces. I know I can love someone properly. I can be loyal, consistent, present. I can show up in ways that actually matter when things get hard, not just when they're easy, and that's where things start to split in my head.

On one side, there's this tired part of me that keeps thinking, maybe this just doesn't work out for people like me. Maybe no matter how much I try, how much I offer, how much I tell them "It's okay, I'm here for you, that's what a boyfriend does." No matter how much unfettered, unfiltered, and unconditional, *capital-L*, **LOVE** I give... I'm still just going to end up being another story someone moves on from.

At the same time, there is another part of me that is filled with anger, or something closer to rage than simple frustration. It is a mixture of disillusionment, disappointment, and a kind of deep emotional pain that is difficult to put into words. Because I recognize something about myself: I am a man of quality. I am, in many ways, what feels absent in the so-called “community” I move through. I am capable of loving with depth and conviction. I am capable of being a loyal partner, a present father, a committed husband, and a devoted lover.

And that is where the contradiction hurts. I am not someone meant to be discarded when things become difficult. If anything, I feel I am the kind of person who should be valued precisely at those moments. Someone worth holding onto, not letting go. “If I bring you comfort, why leave? If I ease your pain, why walk away? If I make you feel safe, why abandon that safety?” It does not make sense to me.

And so I am left trying to understand whether I was never truly valued to begin with, or whether they are self-sabotaging out of fear, doubt, or an inability to believe that something stable and genuine is actually in front of them. At the end of the day, I am left with a deep, unignorable gut feeling that something was left unsaid. It becomes unbearable not knowing the full story. There is no real answer, no closure, no resolution I can hold onto. After everything I gave, after the effort, the care, the love. It feels almost insulting to not even be considered. Although, sometimes that non-answer, is a kind of soft answer. I may never know...

II. Why the Desert Exists: The Collapse of Trust

Puerto Rico gives this problem a particular shape. This is a small island. Everybody knows somebody who knows somebody. Your date might know your ex. Your hookup might know your cousin. Your coworker might know the person you matched with last week. Screenshots travel quickly. Gossip travels quickly. Stories travel quickly. Anonymity exists in theory, but rarely in practice. Reputation becomes a form of currency. People learn to guard information carefully because they know that whatever they share today may become tomorrow's conversation in someone else's group chat.

On top of this sits the influence of machismo, religion, and family expectations. Many Puerto Ricans grow up learning that appearances matter. Respectability matters. Family reputation matters. The question of *¿qué dirán?* follows people well into adulthood. What will people say? Not just strangers, but mothers, grandmothers, neighbors, coworkers, etc

Many of us learn to hide parts of ourselves long before we ever enter a relationship. We become experts at compartmentalization. We learn how to present different versions of ourselves to different audiences. Over time, those habits become difficult to abandon. When enough people are hiding something, everyone begins expecting deception.

Eventually, skepticism becomes the default setting.

III. Harem Builders

The “harem builder” is not just someone who is promiscuous or socially active. In my experience, it is a very specific psychological pattern. These are individuals who seem to thrive on attention itself, almost as if attention is the real currency they are addicted to. It is never enough to be liked, desired, or pursued by a few people. There is a constant need for more validation, admiration, and orbiting presence. An ever increasing number of people watching, wanting, and affirming them.

At the center of this behavior, there often seems to be an ego that is both inflated and fragile at the same time. On the surface, they appear confident, socially skilled, even magnetic. But underneath that, there is often something unstable. A kind of emotional emptiness that no amount of attention actually fills. So instead of confronting that emptiness, they expand outward. They collect people. They accumulate connections the way someone might accumulate proof that they are still desirable, powerful, and most importantly, in control. In that sense, relationships stop being relationships. They become networks. People become roles: validation sources, backup options, temporary escapes, emotional safety nets, status symbols. And because the goal is accumulation rather than depth, honesty becomes secondary. Boundaries blur. Expectations are managed just enough to avoid accountability, but not enough to create real clarity for others involved. What emerges is something that feels like a harem in effect, though never in name or honest agreement.

What makes this dynamic especially damaging is that it is not always obviously malicious in appearance. In many cases, it is often compensatory. It feels like a way of running from something internal that they do not know how to sit with. A void that gets temporarily numbed through attention, desire, and control over social perception. I even feel a kind of pity for it at times. Because it does not look like peace. It looks like compulsion. It looks like someone constantly moving, constantly collecting, constantly trying to outrun something that never actually stops following them.

But that does not absolve the harm it causes. A broken pattern does not stop being destructive just because it has a cause. In fact, it often spreads its damage precisely because it is unexamined. People get pulled into it, misled by intensity or charm, and then discarded or managed when they no longer serve the emotional ecosystem being maintained. There is a difficult truth in that. Hurt people do hurt people. But understanding the wound does not cancel the impact. A person can be shaped by their pain and still be responsible for what they do with it.

And over time, what this creates is not just individual harm, but imitation. Others begin to adapt to it, consciously or unconsciously. People become more guarded, more transactional, more strategic in how they connect. Trust erodes, not only because of one person’s behavior, but because that behavior becomes part of the wider emotional environment. That is where the real damage compounds. The cycle does not stay contained. It reproduces itself.

IV. The Death of the Classic Relationship

Trust is the foundation of any lasting relationship. When trust begins to disappear, relationships become increasingly difficult to sustain.

One of the defining characteristics of modern dating culture is the belief that there is always another option waiting just beyond the horizon. Dating applications place thousands of potential partners a few taps away. The result is a mentality that often resembles consumer behavior more than human connection. People have been accustomed to browse other people. To compare them, evaluate, upgrade, and replace. Commitment begins to feel irrational because alternatives always appear available. Many people want the comfort of companionship without the sacrifices that companionship requires. They want intimacy without vulnerability. Stability without responsibility. Loyalty without obligation. Ghosting becomes normal. Situationships become common. Ambiguity becomes safer than honesty.

The classic relationship, built around mutual commitment and long-term investment, begins to look increasingly fragile in an environment designed around constant alternatives. The tragedy is not that relationships end, because relationships have always ended. The tragedy is that many people seem unwilling to fully enter them in the first place.

V. Hierarchies of Desire: "No Fats, No Fems" and Other Contradictions

The LGBT community often speaks the language of acceptance while simultaneously constructing elaborate hierarchies of desirability. Some of these hierarchies are obvious. They start with body type, age. But soon devolve into race, "masculinity", socio-economic status, etc. Others are less obvious but equally powerful.

The phrase "No fats, no fems" has been criticized for years, and rightly so. It reveals a deep discomfort with femininity and bodies that fall outside narrow standards of attractiveness. Yet there are other contradictions that receive less attention.

Puerto Rico is one of the most racially diverse places in the Caribbean. Most families contain multiple shades and backgrounds. Yet many dating apps seem dominated by white-presenting beauty standards that do not fully reflect the population around us. Colorism and Exoticism remain an uncomfortable subject, but ignoring it does not make it disappear.

Another contradiction involves men who loudly reject feminine men while simultaneously pursuing trans women or highly feminine-presenting partners because that femininity allows them to preserve a particular image of themselves. The issue is not attraction, but the logic behind it. Sometimes, it seems as though femininity becomes acceptable only when it helps someone avoid confronting their own relationship with masculinity and homosexuality.

VI. Machismo: The Ghost That Never Left

Many people speak about machismo as though it belongs to the past. I disagree. Machismo never disappeared. It simply adapted, changed forms, and entered queer spaces.

Its influence can be seen in the obsession with masculinity. It appears in the stigma directed at feminine men. It appears in the fear many men feel about being perceived as "too gay." It appears in the persistent presence of closeted married men living double lives. Some men are willing to have sex with other men while refusing to acknowledge what that means emotionally, socially, or personally.

Others spend years building elaborate systems of secrecy to protect a version of themselves they fear losing. The result is a culture where authenticity often competes against performance. Where appearance frequently matters more than honesty. And vulnerability remains difficult because vulnerability threatens the masculine image so many men have been taught to protect. Machismo continues shaping behavior even among those who believe they have escaped it.

VII. Polyamory, Open Relationships, and Honest Intentions

My criticism is not directed at polyamory itself. Nor is it directed at consensual non-monogamy. Consenting adults should build the relationships that genuinely make sense for them.

The problem arises when these concepts are used dishonestly.

I have seen and been in situations where a relationship is clearly deteriorating, yet instead of ending it, one partner proposes opening it. Not because they have discovered a sincere belief in non-monogamy, but because they want alternatives while avoiding the discomfort of a breakup. In these situations, openness becomes less of a philosophy and more of an escape route. A way of postponing difficult conversations and maintaining emotional security while exploring other options. A "soft breakup"

Likewise, many people dismiss concerns with phrases like "it's just sex." But sex is not just sex for everyone. People attach different meanings to intimacy. They may have different expectations and/or emotional realities. There is nothing wrong with wanting exclusivity, loyalty, and most of all, commitment. Those desires deserve the same respect afforded to any other relationship model. The issue is not the many different ways to express love. The issue is honesty, or lack thereof ...

VIII. The Emotional Cost of Cynicism

Over time, repeated rejection, inconsistency, and emotional ambiguity begin to reshape how you see people. It is not a single moment that does this, but accumulation: a pattern of being set aside when convenient, of forming connections that feel real in the moment but later dissolve without explanation, of realizing that emotional investment is not always met with the same level of care in return.

Eventually, this does not remain an external observation. It becomes internal structure. You stop simply noticing patterns and start anticipating them. You begin to interpret ambiguity not as neutral space, but as early warning. Silence is no longer just silence. Delay is no longer just delay. Emotional distance is no longer just circumstance. Everything starts to feel like the beginning of an ending that you have already experienced before in different forms.

This shifts how you relate to people before anything even fully begins. There is a quiet re-calibration of expectation. You become more measured, more cautious, sometimes even emotionally preemptive. You begin to withhold parts of yourself not because you want to, but because experience has taught you that full presence does not guarantee continuity.

What makes this particularly corrosive is that it does not only affect how you see others. It affects how you see yourself within relationships. There is a gradual erosion of certainty about your place in other people's lives. Even in moments of closeness, there can be an undercurrent of instability, a sense that what feels present today may not necessarily survive tomorrow without warning or explanation.

Over time, this produces a kind of emotional fatigue. Not dramatic or obviously visible, but persistent. A tiredness that comes from repeatedly re-calibrating your expectations to match outcomes that do not align with intention. You begin to invest energy not only into connecting, but into preparing for disconnection.

The result is not a resolution, but a tension that stays with you. A form of cynicism that does not arrive as certainty, but as something more unstable: a learned expectation that must constantly be fought against in order to still allow yourself to care at all.

And yet, even this adaptation comes at a cost. Because what you are adapting to is not just disappointment, but repetition. The same emotional structure, repeated across different faces, different names, different circumstances, until the experience begins to lose its individuality and becomes something more like a pattern of climate.

This is where the idea of emotional desertification becomes unavoidable.

A desert is not defined by the absence of life, but by the absence of conditions that allow life to sustain itself. In the same way, what begins to disappear here is not desire, not attraction, not even the capacity for connection. What disappears is the environment that allows those things to take root and endure. Trust thins. Emotional reciprocity becomes unreliable. Vulnerability begins to feel costly rather than natural. Over time, the internal landscape adjusts to match the external one.

You still meet people. You still speak, desire, connect, try. But something in the ground has changed. What once might have grown into something stable now struggles to survive repeated exposure to inconsistency and withdrawal. So even genuine moments begin to feel fragile, as if they are growing in soil that no longer fully supports them.

The emotional response to this is not immediate collapse, but gradual hardening. A slow shift from openness to calibration, from trust to prediction, from engagement to guarded participation. Cynicism, in this sense, is not born from hatred of others, but from repeated encounters with a relational environment that does not reliably sustain what is given into it.

And still, underneath it all, there remains a tension that does not resolve cleanly. A part of you that remembers what connection can feel like when it is mutual and steady, and another part that has learned to expect its eventual withdrawal. You exist between those two states, not fully resigned, not fully open, but shaped by the distance between what you want from connection and what it has repeatedly become in practice.

That is the desert. Not the absence of feeling, but the slow erosion of the conditions that allow feeling to remain safely rooted.

IX. The Courage to Want More

Despite everything, this is not an essay about the end of desire.

It is an essay about what happens when desire is repeatedly met with disappointment, and how that shapes the way people begin to understand themselves and others. Behind the cynicism, there remains a simple truth: most people still want connection. Most people still want to be seen, chosen, and understood. Most people still want something real, even if they struggle to admit it or sustain it. The tragedy is not that love is impossible, but that so many people begin to believe they are not worthy of it, or that it is not worth pursuing.

And yet the need does not disappear. It persists underneath the armor, the humor, the detachment, and the performances. To want more in a culture that normalizes less is itself an act of resistance. Even when it feels naïve, exhausting or feels like it will lead to disappointment again. The desire, remains.

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